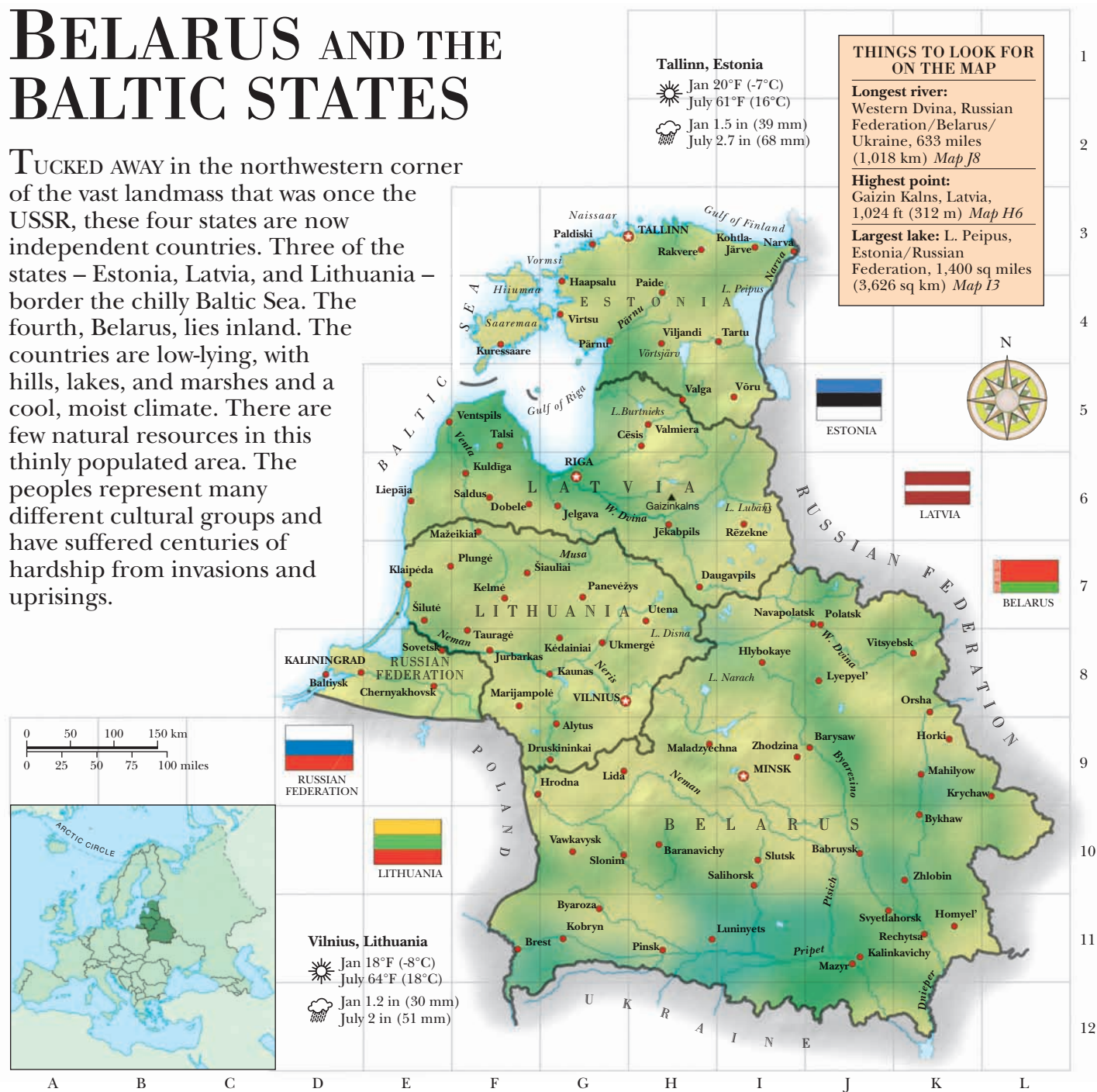


BELARUS AND THE BALTIC STATES

TUCKED AWAY in the northwestern corner of the vast landmass that was once the USSR, these four states are now independent countries. Three of the states – Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania – border the chilly Baltic Sea. The fourth, Belarus, lies inland. The countries are low-lying, with hills, lakes, and marshes and a cool, moist climate. There are few natural resources in this thinly populated area. The peoples represent many different cultural groups and have suffered centuries of hardship from invasions and uprisings.



FARMING AND FISHING

Lack of good farmland and a cold, damp climate limit the range of crops that can be grown in this region. The main crops are cereals, potatoes, and sugar beets. Cattle graze on the wet pastures. Fishing is an important industry in the Baltic States.



INDEPENDENCE

The three Baltic States' struggle for independence during the 1980s played a large part in the USSR's breakup into many separate republics in 1991. At one point, as a form of protest, the people of these states formed a massive human chain across their lands. These Baltic peoples are now trying to forge closer links with neighboring countries, and all three states have joined the EU.

Tawny owls find shelter in the region's dense forests. At night they fly over farmland, hunting for prey.

